
MILIND SHELTE

ratis. Their dominance in this industry, however, has opened the floodgates for illegal migration in recent years. "Legal migrants who went to the US before 2010 have turned to cheap labour—mostly distant relatives from their native villages," says Ahmedabad businessman Dharmendra Patel, who too has kin in the US. With legal avenues for migration drying up in Donald Trump's reign (2017-21), many Indians took to the illegal route.

The Gujarat police believes the migrants are sent to the US border through a wide network of agents in Ahmedabad and north Gujarat. These agents are plugged into a wider human smuggling and trafficking network in Mexico, Canada and the US. Wannabe migrants pay between Rs 50 lakh and Rs 1.1 crore per person to their human smugglers. Estimates prepared by the Gujarat police and NGOs show a near-tenfold rise in the number of human smuggling cases in the past four years, up to 900 in 2021-22. A March 2021 report by US-based think-tank New American Economy estimated that there were close to 500,000 undocumented Indian migrants in the country in 2020, with a collective spending power of $15.5 billion (Rs 1.2 lakh crore).

Stories of Patels staking everything and making it big in the US are legion in north Gujarat. The region, with six districts including Gandhinagar, is less developed than the Saurashtra and south Gujarat regions and accounts for the bulk of illegals. In September 2019, Jayesh Patel, 32, was arrested at Delhi airport trying to board a flight to New York disguised as a wheelchair-bound 81-year-old. The electrician from Ahmedabad was exposed by the black hair on his arms. He was travelling to the US at the behest of a female relative there.

Just how swiftly these dreams can become nightmares unfolded this February 13. The Gandhinagar police rescued 15 Gujaratis, all Patels, in Delhi. The group had been illegally confined there by traffickers. The Gandhinagar police have arrested a local agent, Rajesh Patel, while three alleged traffickers—Kolkata residents Sushil Roy and Santosh Roy, and Kamal Singhania from Delhi—are on the run. They forced the 15 people at gunpoint to inform family members that they had reached the US and then extorted Rs 3.5 crore, money that was to be paid after they reached the US.

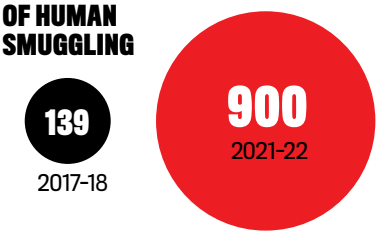
A Gandhinagar police officer says one of the residents had paid Rs 1.6 crore to the agents to take his family to the US. Another had paid Rs 81 lakh for tickets and illegal transportation. Mitesh Patel, 39, one of the victims freed from the travel agents, had the Vasai police station in Mehsana district file an FIR. He said he was trying to enter the US illegally with wife Sheetal and their two young children because he could not get a passport (he was out on bail in a criminal case). "An acquaintance, Amrut Patel, told me about an agent who helped people shift to Canada without a passport. He got me in touch with agent Ramesh Patel. He met me with Sushil Roy who said he would send us to Canada without a passport for Rs 1.11 crore each," Mitesh has been quoted as saying in the FIR. Mitesh and his family reached Kolkata via Mumbai on November 14, 2021. Singhania told him that their flight to Canada was booked for November 28, 2021. However, the traffickers took them to a hotel and locked them there. "They forcibly took my daughter and kept her in another room and demanded another Rs 25 lakh. They looted our jewellery and some US dollars. We paid them Rs 1.57 crore over two-and-a-half months," says Mitesh.

Police got leads in the case while investigating a secret tip-off that a couple, who had left Gandhinagar for Canada, was confined in a hotel in Delhi. The couple had managed to contact their relatives

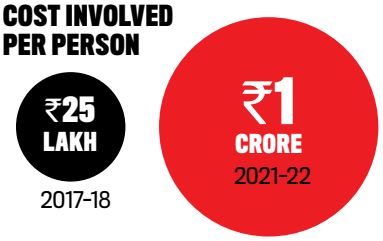
GONE IN THE USA

Illegal immigration cases from India have exploded in the last 3 years

SUSPECTED CASES OF HUMAN SMUGGLING



COST INVOLVED PER PERSON



Source: Gujarat Police, community leaders